the EAGs was discussion about federalism, including the establishment of a federal system followed by a federal army (Kuok 2014). But the Tatmadaw did not agree to discuss the issue in official meetings until three years into the negotiation process. On 15 August 2014, the peace technical team managed to secure the Tatmadaw's official agreement to discuss a possible federal system of government in peace talks. But the federal army issue has been left to settle in future discussions.

From a formal perspective, the agreement on talks over a federal system of government made during official meetings is legitimate. But a more thorny issue, the discussion of a federal army, has been left for the future. Therefore, it captures the features of a piecemeal approach where policy actors handle complex issues incrementally, that is, without taking a holistic view.

It can be argued that the peace technical team binds the Tatmadaw through its official commitment to the peace process while reducing possible risks associated with making commitments. It is obvious that an agreement on a federal system involves ideological and security risks for the Tatmadaw. In the past, the Tatmadaw had considered the term "federalism" as a threat to national unity (Collin and Martin 2012, p. 283). It strongly rejected any moves toward the idea, treating them as a prelude for the break up of the country. Therefore, the federalism issue has become one of the most pressing obstacles between the Tatmadaw and the EAGs over the last sixty years of successive military regimes.

Although the peace policy community and the EAGs had been discussing a federal system of government during their bilateral talks, the Tatmadaw initially appeared to be against the federal concept as a whole (both the federal system and federal army ideas) during the first two years of the negotiation process. The Tatmadaw refused to use the term "federal" in the single-text agreement draft, a combination document of a separate proposal from the Myanmar government and EAGs, before making a nationwide ceasefire agreement (Tun Tun Thein 2014). This became the major barrier for the continuation of peace talks in that period. Moreover, the military commander-in-chief took a position against the establishment of a federal army by stating that the union army already existed, referring to the Myanmar military. Consequently, when the EAGs pressed the federal issue in peace discussions, the Tatmadaw showed strong resistance to cooperating with the government team or the EAGs (interview with senior members of the UPWC, 2015).